months … All the deterioration later for BJP was because of their rivalry. This rivalry was also caused by the party's central high command which was a divided house with two factions—for and against Yediyurappa.'[97]

While the Lingayats moved to the BJP, the other big social group in Karnataka, the Vokkaligas, who make up about 15 per cent of the population, moved to Deve Gowda's JD(S), the social base for which continues to be the Old Mysore region. Interestingly, while the BJP did appropriate some Vokkaliga leaders, it has never really targeted the community's vote aggressively, like it has with other social groups. Partly, this was because the BJP's own Vokkaliga leaders felt it was a pointless exercise. 'They have a huge inferiority complex in our party and are always in awe of the Deve Gowda family. Nobody ever wanted to personally antagonise the Deve Gowda family,' said a senior party leader. 'Even some of our senior Vokkaliga leaders played convenient politics not to antagonise Deve Gowda. They would go to take his aashirwad to win and do morning hazri at his house [rather than] try and beat him. They never thought of challenging the Gowda family directly. They used to say "aashirwad dein" [please give blessings].'[98] This began to change after 2019, with the BJP making a determined push into Vokkaliga areas. 'In Bengaluru City, we got 28 per cent of Vokkaliga vote, Congress got 17–19 per cent, JD(S) got 10–11 per cent. So Vokkaligas are turning more in favour of us now,' said B.Y. Vijayendra. 'We are now trying to have a positive presence in Old Mysore. We never attempted anything here but now we do.'

Traditionally, the BJP has had very little presence in Hyderabad–Karnataka (dominated by the Congress) and Mysore–Karnataka (dominated by the JD(S)). 'Now we have chance there [Hyderabad–Karnataka] because Mallikarjun Kharge is getting old. We are aggressively looking to target Old Mysore and Hyderabad-Karnataka,' he said.[99]

BJP leaders regard their victory in the Krishnarajpet by-election in Mandya district in December 2019 as a turning point for them in the Old Mysore region. It was a seat that the BJP had never won before and was followed by the defeat of Deve Gowda's grandson, Nikhil Kumaraswamy, in Mandya in the 2019 Lok Sabha election.